

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

entire descent is left to the wisdom of Vikram [lander]; so that is the test of how well you have trained this boy to handle the situation on his own. It is just like training a soldier and sending him to the front and leaving it to his decision. Also, we were accountable to the entire nation. More so to the Honourable Prime Minister because after Chandrayaan-2, he said that sometimes not being successful is a step towards being successful. That was a wonderful message. We had to live up to it. When [Vikram] landed successfully, all of us jumped out of our chairs and clapped. It was so spontaneous.

Q. What are the next big things for the space programme?

Apart from Aditya-1, then Gaganyaan and Venus [orbiter] simultaneously, we are going to have a huge number of launches from the private sector. This also happened after the prime minister took the courageous decision to completely open up the space sector to private parties in the country. As a result, there is a quantum jump in our space missions. We now have a collaboration with virtually most of the countries. The best part of the collaboration with Russia and America is that we are no longer the lesser cousin. We are now equal partners and, in many ways, more than equal. For example, now we are lending services to America and Russia...we already earned more than $170 million. We now do $8 billion (Rs 66,000 crore) of business. But at the pace we are rising, India could go up to $40 billion (Rs 3.3 lakh crore) by 2040 in the space sector, a recent report by a reputed agency has said.

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Q. So you are saying the PM's decision in 2020 to open the space sector for private industry to manufacture rockets and satellites, instead of just ISRO, has been a game-changer?

Absolutely! I never hesitate to say this time and again. One thing is proven, there is no dearth of talent in India. We have talent, we have calibre and competence.... For too long, we unnecessarily had a veil of secrecy and confined ourselves to ISRO. This was no longer required. Now, in addition to the private industry investment, we have this whole ecosystem that includes the National Research Foundation legislation, which allocates Rs 50,000 crore to be spent with Rs 36,000 crore coming from the non-governmental sector.

Q. What would be the impact?

It is very progressive thinking because from now onwards, if we have to go, we have to go wholesomely. You cannot depend on government resources alone. If we have to visualise a global role for ourselves, then we have to have global parameters and a global strategy. That is what Americans are doing; NASA is no longer depending on government resources. The process of synergy is happening, and in just three years, we have more than 150 private start-ups in the space sector. So, we are heading towards a scenario where with little demarcation between public and private sectors, it will be a totally integrated approach.

Q. Finally, why should we be spending on projects to the moon instead of development?

I am often asked this question, saying that it is a costly affair. A moon project is not. It is just Rs 600 crore; not even a fraction of what other countries are spending and just about what it costs to construct a section of a big bridge across a river. Even our expressways cost us more. So, one aspect is that we are very cost-effective. The second part is that if Chandrayaan-3 actually succeeds in discovering minerals and petroleum, all those things would be adding value to our lives even on Earth. Thirdly, the kind of esteem it gives to the nation. Especially if we are looking forward to playing a global role, we have to get global recognition. ■